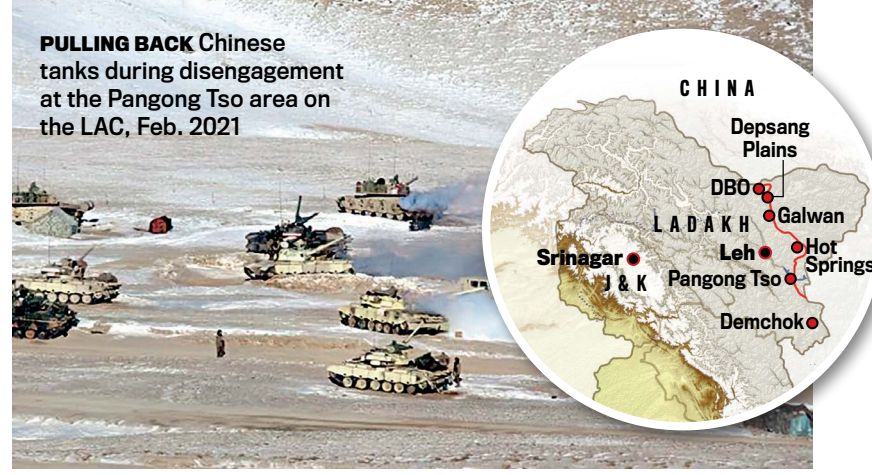


PULLING BACK Chinese tanks during disengagement at the Pangong Tso area on the LAC, Feb. 2021

puted areas held out tenaciously against any resolution. Now, patrolling rights in these areas—Depsang plains and Demchok, where thousands of troops remain deployed—are restored to both armies. The 73-day Doklam stand-off in 2017 was resolved in a similar fashion just days before Modi's visit to Beijing for another BRICS summit.

External affairs minister S. Jaishankar stated that the new "patrolling arrangement" and the concomitant disengagement process would restore the situation to its pre-2020 status. However, he cautioned, "This has just happened; there will be further meetings to determine the next steps. I wouldn't jump ahead too quickly." On October 23, the Chinese foreign ministry said, "Currently, the two sides have reached a solution on the relevant matters.... In the next phase, China will work with India to effectively implement the solution plan."

ROAD TO NORMALCY

- **On October 21, India announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the LAC with China in Eastern Ladakh**
- **It set the stage for a bilateral meeting between PM Modi and President Xi on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit in Russia on Oct. 23**
- **This will lead to disengagement of troops of the two nations at the remaining two points of contention: Depsang Plains and Demchok**
- **It is believed that Chinese troops will no longer obstruct Indian soldiers, and vice versa, at the 'bottleneck' area in the strategically significant 800 sq. km Depsang Plains**
- **Both sides to reduce number of patrolling personnel, coordinate patrolling to prevent clashes**
- **Local military commanders to meet and finalise disengagement; both sides to complete verification through physical inspections, drone surveillance**
- **Earlier disengagements took place at Hot Springs, Galwan, Gogra and Pangong Tso, and buffer zones were created**
- **Till date, 21 rounds of corps commander-level talks and 31 rounds of diplomatic talks under the ministry of external affairs have been held between India and China**

There have been signs of a thaw recently. On September 13, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval met Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi in Russia, where both sides agreed to expedite "complete disengagement" along the LAC. On the same day, Jaishankar remarked that 75 per cent of "disengagement problems" had been resolved.

The face-off at the LAC flared up in June 2020 at the Galwan Valley, when, in a bloody clash, 20 Indian army soldiers and an unspecified number of People's Liberation Army (PLA) personnel were killed. There were six friction points—Galwan, Hot Springs, Gogra, Pangong Tso, Depsang Plains and Demchok. After that, 21 rounds of corps commander-level talks and 31 rounds of the Working Mechanism for Consultation & Coordination (WMCC) under the ministry of external affairs have been held with China. Through them, disengagements occurred at Hot Springs, Galwan, Gogra and Pangong Tso, and buffer zones were created. Now, finally, some normality returns to Depsang and Demchok. Patrolling at the flashpoints will ideally lead to full disengagement and, finally, by de-induction of military assets.

While details of the agreement are unclear, it is believed that Chinese troops will no longer obstruct Indian soldiers, and vice versa, at the 'bottleneck' area in strategically significant Depsang, located about 30 km south-east of the vital Daulat Beg Oldie post near the Karakoram Pass in the north. "Both sides will relocate the temporary positions and posts they had set up. A similar disengagement will occur at the Charding Ninglung Nallah near Demchok in the south," an official source indicates. However, there is no clarity if the pullback will restore Indian troops' full access to their traditional patrolling points (PPs) 10 to 13 in Depsang. Sources note that patrolling will continue "in all areas" twice a month. It is believed that both sides have agreed to reduce the number of patrolling personnel to less than 15 (from the usual 20) to prevent clashes. Disengagement is expected to take around 10 days, as both sides must complete verification through physical inspections and drone surveillance.

The 3 km-long (1.5 km on either side) buffer zone created after the Galwan clash, and similar zones in Gogra, Hot Springs and Pangong Tso, are demilitarised areas where neither side is allowed to patrol. Now, military observers are asking if the temporary moratorium on patrolling here would be lifted and